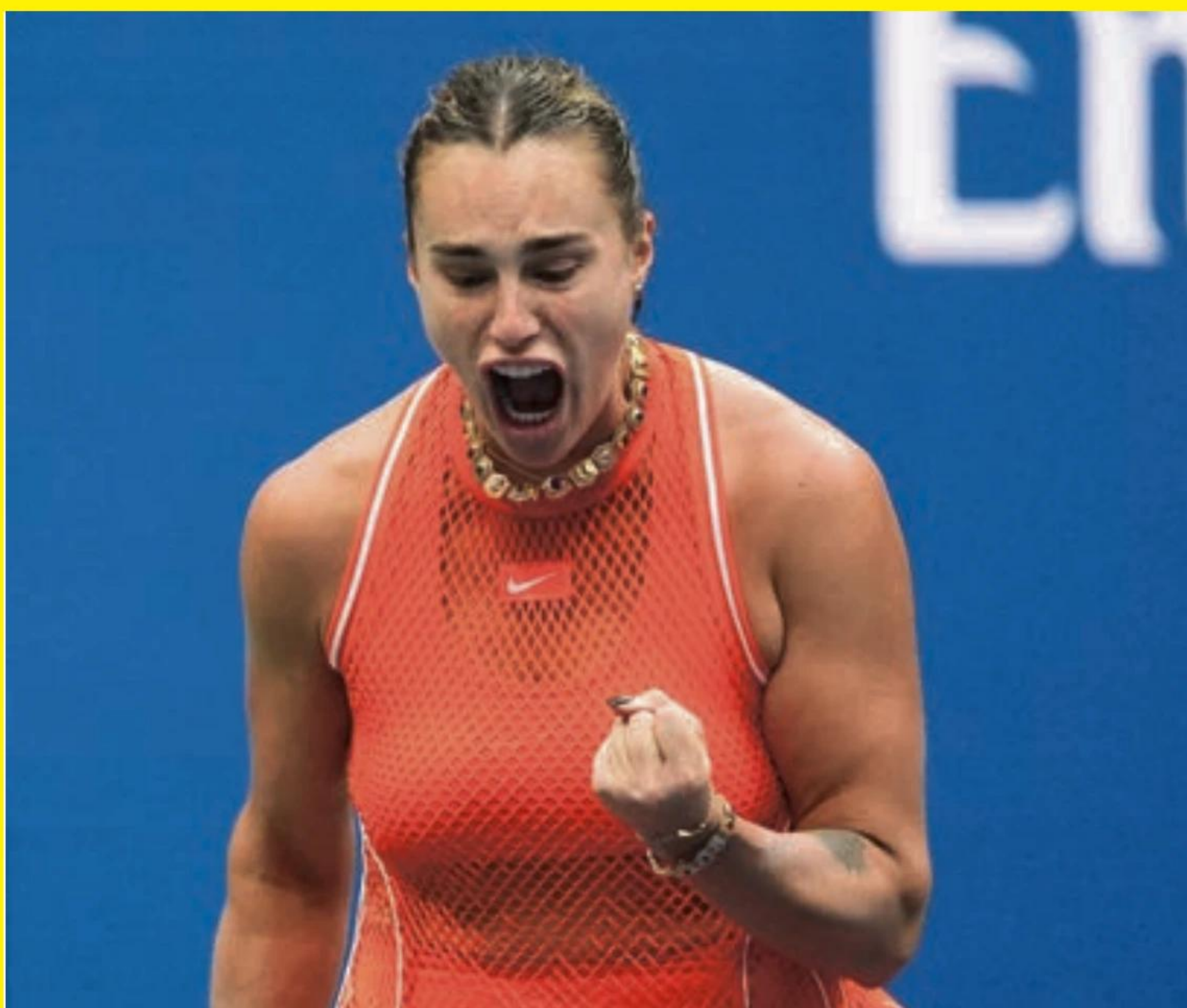




History hunt: Defending champion Aryna Sabalenka was aiming to be the third woman in the Open era to achieve a three-peat at the US Open.

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Zheng removed any lingering doubts that she was back after her close 3-6, 6-1, 6-4 quarterfinal loss to Rybakina. Hitting her spots on her serve and redirecting the Kazakh's powerful groundstrokes, China's best player since two-time Major champion Li Na should return to the top 10 next year. Zheng viewed the setback philosophically:

"Losing a match is not just about tennis. It's more about something within yourself."

The quarterfinal pitting No. 4 Gauff and No. 5 Andreieva, the French Open champion, promised a lot but delivered little. The calibre of play was low throughout, as Gauff choked in the first half of the match, and Andreieva choked in the second half. Both displayed formidable backhands but far too many forehand errors and generally timid shots.

Gauff prevailed 2-6, 7-6(7), 6-2 mainly because she competed despite her frustration, while the petulant Andreieva looked like she'd rather be anywhere else. For the 12th time this season, Gauff rallied to win after losing the first set.

Great offence beats great defence these days, and nobody exemplifies that like Rybakina (**below**). She led the WTA Tour in aces and tied Sabalenka for No. 1 in service games won percentage, 81.5. The Kazakh's impeccable technique generates power on every stroke, except the backhand volley, and she weathers crises with uncommon sang-froid.

Gauff has a big edge in speed and agility, competes tenaciously, and claims: "I haven't been tired since I was 14." She also knows how to use the fiercely pro-American crowd, especially when the going gets tough. Gauff was hot, riding an 11-match winning streak since losing to Rybakina in Toronto.

In the opening set of her semifinal against Rybakina, Gauff deployed three tactics: retreating 8 to 10 feet behind the baseline to return second serves, extending rallies, and quickly switching from defence to offence. The plan worked beautifully. She took the opener 6-3 with eight winners versus only seven unforced



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